CHAPTER 1

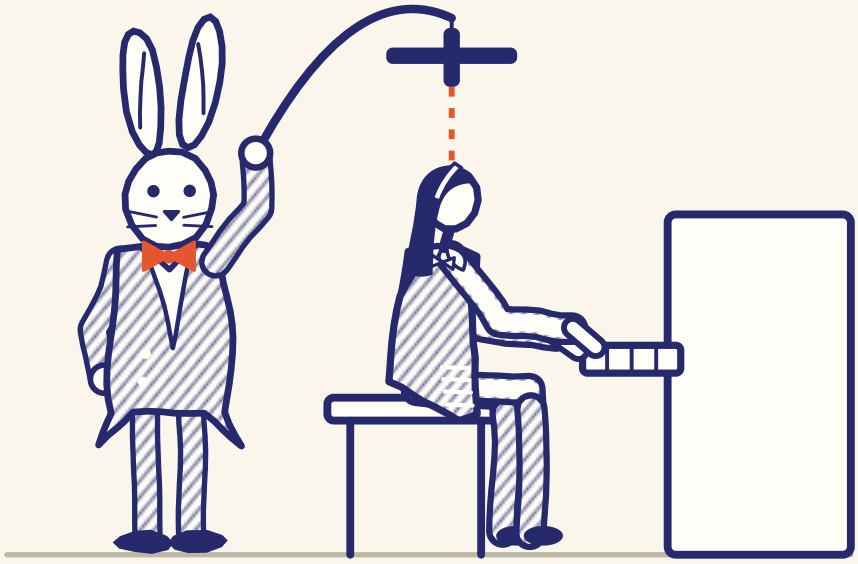
Posture & Hand Shape

Lesson Book + Workbook



CHAPTER 1

Posture & Hand Shape



Sit tall, like a puppet on a string

Before the first note: how to sit, and how to hold your hands. Get these right, and every note after them is easier.

In this chapter

Sit at the piano	page 2
Let the arm carry the hand	page 3
A round hand	page 4
Finger numbers	page 5
Play: finger walks	page 6
My five checks	page 7

By the end, you can

- [ ] sit at the right height and distance
- [ ] move your hand with the whole arm
- [ ] make a round hand and play on the tips
- [ ] say every finger number, on both hands

Goes with: the Workbook page beside each lesson page, and the online lesson.

CHAPTER 1

Posture & Hand Shape

Each workbook page faces its Lesson Book page: read the left page, then do the right one.

Your map for this chapter

One lesson step at a time: read it, do its page, try it online. Tick each step when the page is done.

1 · LESSON BOOK
Read one step.

→

2 · WORKBOOK
Do that step's page.

→

3 · APP
Scan the page's code: try the step, then play the drill.

→

4 · CHECK-UP
Page 7, when every step is done.

Lesson step	Workbook page	What it covers	Done
Step 1	page 2	Sitting at the piano	☐
Step 2	page 3	The arm leads	☐
Step 3	page 4	A round hand	☐
Step 4	page 5	Left hand, right hand · Finger numbers	☐
Step 5	page 6	Finger walks	☐
Step 6	page 7	My five checks	☐

ONLINE

The drill

Scan, then pick a level. Aim for 9 out of 10.

1. Is the stool set up right? best ___/10
2. Spot the hand-shape fault best ___/10
3. Which finger? best ___/10

At the piano

Real-piano missions for this chapter. Tick one box each time you do it.

1. Before you play, every time: front half of the stool, feet flat, sit tall, leaning a little toward the piano. ☐ ☐ ☐
2. The six warm-ups in order, from the big parts of the body to the small. ☐ ☐ ☐
3. A round hand on your knee, like holding a ball, then onto the keys. The wrist stays free, as if on a roller. ☐ ☐ ☐
4. Finger walks: one note, then two, three, four, five. A little rainbow from key to key. ☐ ☐ ☐

The Piano Butler's house

every floor a stage, every room a chapter -- the same order as the app

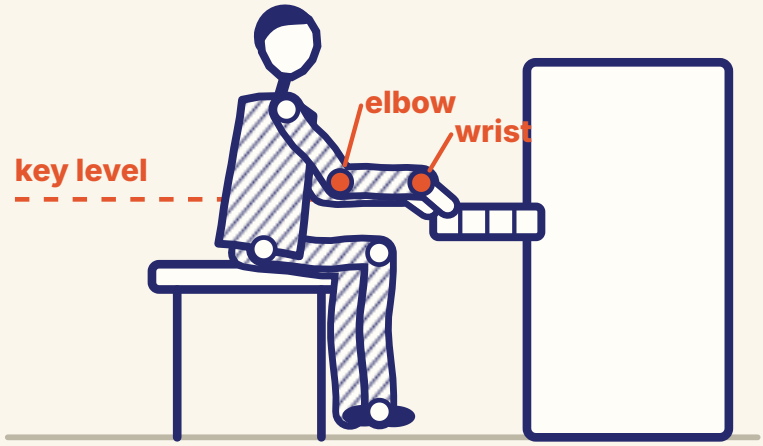
Piano Butler

7 · Know the music	22 The piano	23 Composers	24 Pitch	25 Styles	
6 · Making music	17 Melody	18 Form	19 Loud & soft	20 Signs	21 Terms
5 · Theory	13 Intervals	14 Scales	15 Key signatures	16 Chords	
4 · Reading tunes	11 Steps & skips		12 Tempo		
3 · Rhythm	7 Pulse	8 Note values	9 Time signatures	10 Rhythm	
2 · Reading notes	4 The staff	5 Ledger lines	6 Sharps & flats		
1 · Getting started	1 Posture	2 Patterns	3 Alphabet		

★ **All steps ticked?** Do the Chapter check-up on page 7, then colour in the badge.

Step 1

Sit at the piano

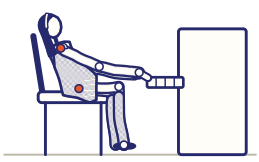


Two things to set: **how high** and **how far**. Your forearm is level with the keys, and your elbows sit just in front of your body.

At the piano

1. Sit on the **front half of the stool**, feet flat on the floor, leaning a little toward the piano. ☐
2. Raise or lower the stool until your **forearm is level** with the keys. ☐
3. Slide in or out until your **elbows are just in front of you**, about a fist away from your sides. ☐

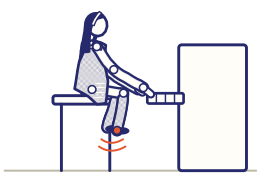
Not like this



× Leaning back, like on a sofa



× So close the elbows squash in



× Too high: feet swinging

REMEMBER **Front half of the stool, feet flat, sit tall, leaning a little forward.**

Lesson step 1

online

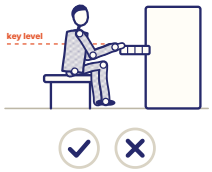
TRY IT Is this a good set-up?

Look at each picture, then try it at the piano. Circle the tick or the cross.

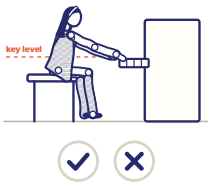
EXAMPLE



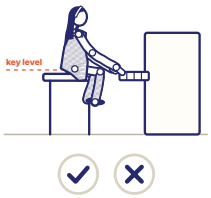
2



3



4



YOUR TURN Set up at home

Before you practise, set up and tick each one. Ask someone at home to check, or use a mirror.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
Front half of the stool	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Feet flat, leaning a little toward the piano	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sit tall, like a puppet on a string	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Forearm level with the keys	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Elbows away from your body	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Draw yourself at the piano

Draw yourself sitting at the piano. Then colour a star for each thing you drew.

- ☆ sitting tall
- ☆ feet flat
- ☆ leaning a little forward
- ☆ elbows away from the body
- ☆ round hands

How did it feel? Circle one. Checked ☐

Step 2

Let the arm carry the hand

Your fingertips stay connected to the piano, but the **whole arm** does the work: from above, it leads the hand and the fingers. Six moves, **in this order**, from the big parts of the body to the small ones: each one gets the arm ready for the next.



1 Rag doll

Flop forward and let both arms hang heavy. Shake them loose, then float the hands up and set them gently on the keys.



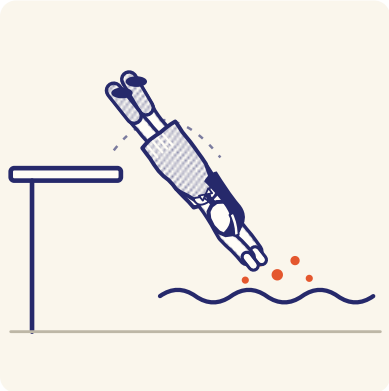
2 Elbow wings

Check the elbows are free, not stuck to your body: let them float out like wings, then back. Stop in the middle, a fist from your body.



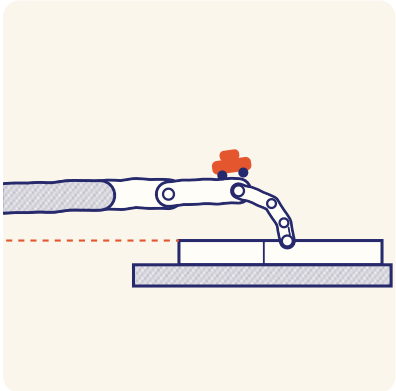
3 Arm glide

Now the whole arm: skate along the keys. The round hand rides on the arm to the next group of keys. The fingers ride, they don't walk.



4 Arm drop

Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.



5 Knuckle bridge

Check the bridge: your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3: the bridge stays up.



6 Wrist balloon

Check the wrist never sinks: as the key goes down, a balloon lifts the wrist straight back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

REMEMBER **The arm leads from above, elbows free. Even while a finger presses a key, the whole arm stays free.**

Lesson step 2 online

TRY IT Put the warm-ups in order

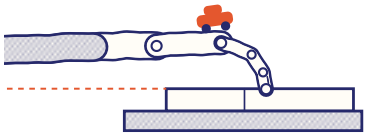
Big parts of the body first, small parts last. Write 1 to 6 under the pictures. The first one is done.

EXAMPLE



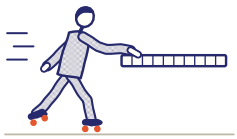
Rag doll 1

2



Knuckle bridge

3



Arm glide

4



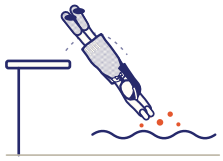
Wrist balloon

5



Elbow wings

6



Arm drop

YOUR TURN My warm-ups this week

Do the six in order before you practise. Tick a box for each one you did.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1 Rag doll	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 Elbow wings	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 Arm glide	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4 Arm drop	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5 Knuckle bridge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6 Wrist balloon	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

YOUR TURN Yes or no?

Circle yes or no.

1 **The arm leads from above.** yes no

2 **My elbows stay stuck to my body.** yes no

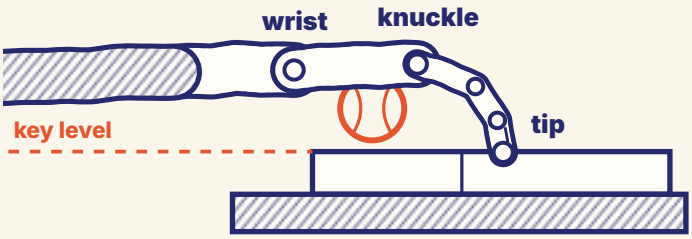
3 **Even while a finger presses a key, the whole arm stays free.** yes no

4 **After a key goes down, my wrist sinks below the keys.** yes no

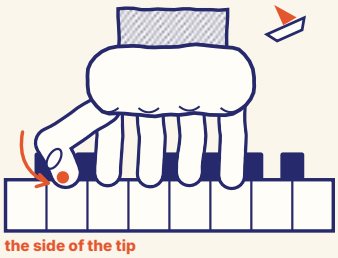
How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 3

A round hand



Round, like holding a ball



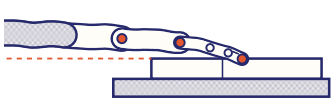
The thumb bends in and plays on the side of its tip, like a tipped boat

Let your arms hang, then lift your hands as if you were holding a small ball. Keep that shape when the hand goes on the keys. **Knuckles up** like a bridge, and play on the **fingertips**. The wrist stays free: with the fingertip on the key, the hand can sway up and down and side to side, as if a **roller** sat under your forearm.

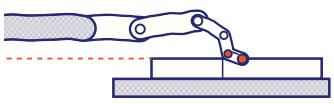
At the piano

1. Hands on your knees. Hold an imaginary ball. ☐
2. Move the ball shape onto the keys without squashing it. ☐
3. Play one key with each finger, on the tip. The knuckles stay up. ☐
4. Fingertip on a key: sway the wrist up and down, then side to side, as if on a roller. Notice the knuckles and the tip, and try not to let them cave in. ☐

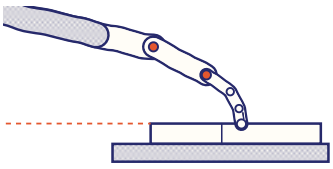
Not like this



× Flat fingers



× Tip joint caving in



× Wrist stiff and high

REMEMBER **A free wrist, as if on a roller. Keep an eye on the knuckles and fingertips.**

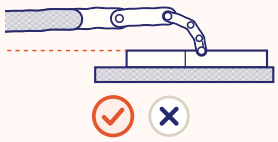
Lesson step 3

online

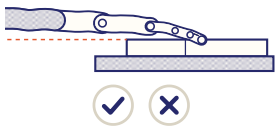
TRY IT Spot the good hand

Circle the tick for the good hand shape and the cross for a fault. Then say what is wrong.

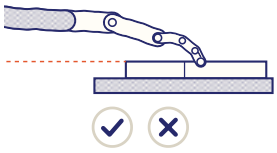
EXAMPLE



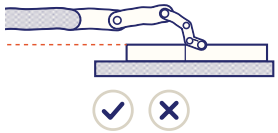
2



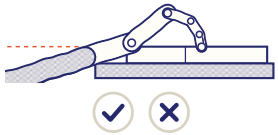
3



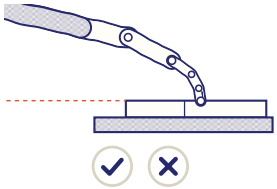
4



5



6



YOUR TURN Roller wrist and thumb

Do each one at the piano and tick a box each day.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
Fingertip on a key: sway the wrist up and down, then side to side	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Knuckles up, like a bridge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The thumb bends in and plays on the side of its tip	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Hold the bubble

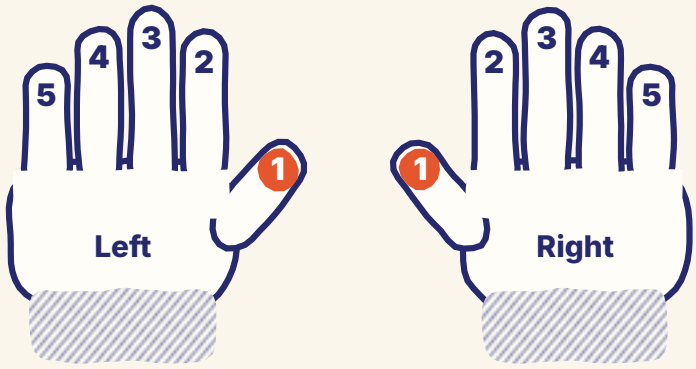
Hold a small ball (or a mandarin) in a round hand. Draw your hand round it, then colour a star for each.

- ☆ knuckles up
- ☆ round fingers
- ☆ playing on the tips
- ☆ the thumb on its side

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 4

Finger numbers



Every finger has a number, **1 to 5, starting from the thumb**. It's the same on both hands: both thumbs are 1, and both little fingers are 5.

1 Captain Thumb **2 Pointer** **3 Tall Middle** **4 Shy Ring** **5 Baby Pinky**

The mirror game

1. Hold both hands up. Wiggle each finger as you say its number. ☐
2. Someone calls "Right hand, 3!" and you wiggle it. Try ten calls. ☐
3. Swap: you call the finger, and they wiggle it. ☐



REMEMBER **Fingers are numbered 1 to 5 from the thumb, on both hands.**

Lesson step 4

online

TRY IT Which finger?

Write the number of the coloured finger. Thumbs are 1 on both hands.

EXAMPLE



4

2



3



4



5



6



★ PLAY Trace your hands

Put each hand flat in its box and draw round it. Write the finger numbers on every finger -- the thumb is 1 on both hands! Then draw a ring on each finger 4.

Left hand

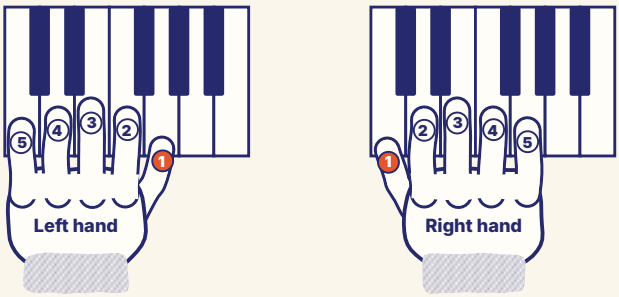
Right hand

Check: ☐ 5 fingers on each hand ☐ Thumbs are 1 ☐ A ring round each finger 4
☐ Left and right the right way round

Play

Finger walks

Now put it together: sit well, make a round hand, and play. **Start small:** one note, then two, three, four, and all five. From key to key, the hand draws a little **rainbow**: relaxed, never squeezed tight, the whole hand helping. **One circle is one steady beat.**





Hop on 3

one note: an arm drop on every 3

3 ○ 3 ○ | 3 3 3 ○



Neighbours

two notes, next door, taking turns

2 3 2 3 | 3 2 3 ○



Up and back

three notes: up, then back down

1 2 3 ○ | 3 2 1 ○



Little hill

four notes: up the hill and down

1 2 3 4 | 3 2 1 ○



Stairs and slide

all five: up the stairs, then down the slide

1 2 3 4 5 ○ | 5 4 3 2 1 ○

An empty dashed circle means: hold the note for one more beat.



REMEMBER **A little rainbow from key to key. Relaxed: the whole hand helps.**

Lesson step 5 online

TRY IT Fill in the missing numbers

Write the missing finger numbers in the coral circles, then play the tune. The first one is done.

Up and back 1 2 3 ◯ | 3 ◯ 1 ◯

Little hill 1 2 ◯ 4 | ◯ 2 1 ◯

Stairs and slide 1 2 3 ◯ 5 ◯ | 5 ◯ 3 2 1 ◯

YOUR TURN Finger walks this week

Play each tune. Tick it when the hand stays round and draws a little rainbow from key to key.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
1 Hop on 3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2 Neighbours	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3 Up and back	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4 Little hill	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5 Stairs and slide	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Make your own finger walk

Write a finger number (1 to 5) in each circle. Leave a circle empty to hold the note. Play it to someone!

◯ ◯ ◯ ◯ | ◯ ◯ ◯ ◯

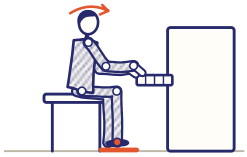
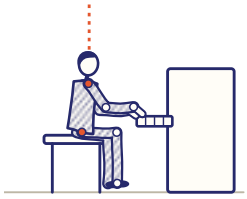
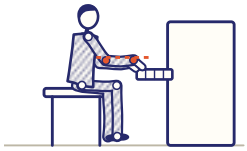
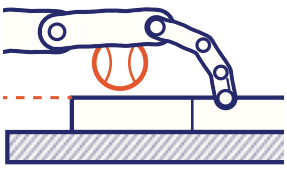
My tune is called _____

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 5

My five checks

Before you play, every time. Give yourself a star for each check in each lesson.

	Lesson 1	2	3	4	5	6
 **Front half of the stool**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Feet flat, leaning a little toward the piano**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Sit tall, like a puppet on a string**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Forearm level with the keys, elbows away from your body**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
 **Round hand, play on the tips**	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

REMEMBER **Check your posture before every practice.**

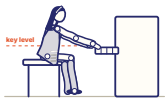
Chapter check-up

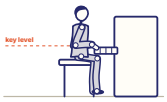
No help, no piano -- about 10 minutes

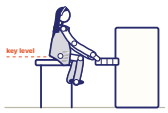
Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 24

A A good set-up? Circle the tick or the cross.

1 

2 

3 

4 

B The arm: yes or no?

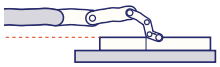
5 I squeeze hard to play loud. yes no

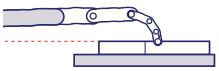
6 Even while a finger presses a key, the whole arm stays free. yes no

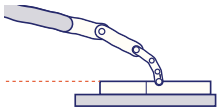
7 The arm leads from above. yes no

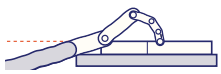
8 After a key goes down, my wrist sinks below the keys. yes no

C A good hand shape? Circle the tick or the cross.

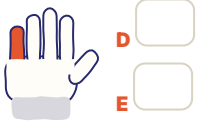
9 

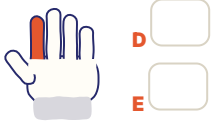
10 

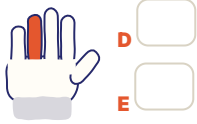
11 

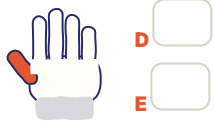
12 

D Left or right hand? Write L or R. E Which finger is coloured?

13 · 17 

14 · 18 

15 · 19 

16 · 20 

F Finger walks: write the missing number.

21 (1) (2) (3) ( ) (5)

22 (5) (4) ( ) (2) (1)

23 (2) (3) (2) ( )

24 (1) ( ) (3) (2) (1)

Concept	Score	Pass mark	Passed?
A Sitting at the piano	___ / 4	3+	☐
B The arm leads	___ / 4	3+	☐
C A round hand	___ / 4	3+	☐
D Left hand, right hand	___ / 4	3+	☐
E Finger numbers	___ / 4	3+	☐
F Finger walks	___ / 4	3+	☐

Chapter complete! Every concept passed? Colour in the badge and add your name to it.